Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Emily Dickinson's "[Nature, the gentlest mothers]"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of Emily Dickinson's characterization of nature in "[Nature, the gentlest of mothers]" include

alliteration,
anthropomorphism,
characterization,
connotation,
consonance,
enjambment,
imagery,
litotes,
metaphor,
paradox,
pathetic fallacy,
personification,
sigmatism,
speaker,
synecdoche, and
tone.

Dickinson's personification of nature as mother is nothing new; however, Dickinson's characterization develops the maternal aspects through metaphor and imagery in a manner that the contestant should be able to appreciate. The young writer should note the patience, care, and affection that the speaker presents as the hallmarks of our personified nature's gentleness. Nature's rôle as caretaker of the forest's denizens is emphasized in the enjambed lines of the first two stanzas—"Her admonition mild / In forest and the hill / By traveler is heard"—and apparently recognized, a recognition that allows the anthropomorphizing of the forest critters: the rampant squirrel and the impetuous bird.

The contestant might recognize the mild admonition (line 4) as pathetic fallacy, and so also nature's "fair conversation" (line 9); both can be argued to be an endowing of nature with human emotion, the mildness and the fairness exceeding the simpler care and affection that are usually ascribed to both the sentient constituents of the natural world and the collective that is nature herself. Indeed, the description of the squirrel as rampant and the bird as impetuous might be seen as pathetic fallacy.

Something might be made of the metaphor and the synecdoche that suggest the forest as church: nature's "voice among the aisles," as well as the cricket's "timid prayer"; both of which are prefaced with a reference to nature's "assembly."